the contest, intently watching every fast, seaming delivery. Concentrate, I urged myself. Focus, get into the line. Don't get out.

In the end, Jan decided enough was enough and hurled the ball at my back. I immediately burst into tears, and my mother emerged from the kitchen to call stumps at the end of an unforgettable day.

I retrieved the Jonty cap and put it on my head. The older boys left, oblivious to my emotions and excitement. I didn't care. I felt worthy and deserving, and that was all that mattered.

Div Park was special.

My brothers made it so.

Our family lived at 20 Mentz Avenue, on a large corner plot not far from the centre of Warmbaths, the town now known as Bela-Bela, an hour's drive north of Pretoria. The garden included large trees and an open lawn at least 30 metres long and 20 metres wide, the ideal location for what the three De Villiers boys considered a proper cricket ground in every respect.

Jan and Wessels thought of everything. They grew the kikuyu grass from seed. They 'borrowed' from the local high school a proper roller, which somehow remained in our garden for a few years. On one occasion, I was woken at 1 am in the morning and told to help roll the wicket for the next day's match.

The three of us were regular players, together with Gerrit Deist, another friend Gerald Pieterse and by far the best player in the group, Martin van Jaarsveld, a friend of my brother Jan.

Martin – or 'Jarre', as we called him – was an exceptionally talented cricketer, 10 years older than me, who played regularly in our garden and who advanced all the way through the Northern Transvaal and Titans provincial squads to make his Test debut for South Africa in 2002. He blazed a trail that I was proud to follow.

At Div Park, there were no rules about retiring when you reached a certain score and Jarre played many, many marathon innings. He would